in a starched and spotlessly white frock made of khadi, she took on one Ms Wills, who had the experience of playing at Wimbledon to awe one and all, in her very first match. With the repertoire of a good forehand and a weak backhand, Kiran lost the match at 0-6, 1-6. But she was thrilled, nevertheless, to have taken a game off a Wimbledon player. Two years hence, she became the national junior champion.

She travelled the length and breadth of the country in pursuit of her game, invariably in the then-existent third-class compartments, at times even perched on her luggage carrier outside the toilet of the coach. There was no prize money worth mentioning in Indian tennis those days and the gender bias being fairly predominant, she had to assert herself time and again and fight for the paltry amounts of travel fare and the like. All money saved would be promptly handed over to her mother. Kiran never liked to keep money with her. Her mother actually had to put money in her pocket but every time it would come back unspent. Her mother would recover that money from her pockets at the time of washing or ironing her clothes. However, from 1968 onwards, when she achieved her national ranking, Kiran became eligible to travel either by air or by first class in trains. Kiran travelled a lot during her student days alone or in groups, staying in dormitories in the beginning and then graduating to single rooms in hotels. She was the contemporary of renowned players such as Vijay Amritraj, Anand Amritraj, Gaurav Misra, Ramanathan Krishnan, Jaideep Mukherjee and Premjit Lal. She played on the same courts that legends like Illie Nastase, Ian Tiriac and Fred Stolle did on their regular visits to India.

Kiran played competitive tennis from the age of thirteen to thirty, when she was well into the Indian Police Service. She was India's number two during her police training at Mount Abu (Rajasthan) when she read in the newspapers that the Indian women's team to tour Sri Lanka had been announced. This team was scheduled to play in the Fonseca Trophy, an Indo–Sri Lanka women's tournament. She did not figure in the team. This omission got her really incensed and she shot off letters of protest to the authorities, who explained to her that they had imagined that as she was now in service, she would not be available to participate. So, while the other members of the team, Nirupama Mankad-Vasant, Susan Dass and Udaya Kumar, practised with trainers and coaches under the auspices of the Lawn Tennis Association of India, Kiran practised with the then director of the National Police Academy, S. J. Gokhale, her fellow probationer, Sanjiv Tripathi, and others, or all by herself against a wall specially constructed for her. Kiran eventually went to Sri Lanka as a member of the team. She won her matches and the Indian team returned home with the Fonseca Trophy in hand.

All the time spent (not to mention the efforts put in) by Kiran on the courts and in travelling did not, however, deter her from her studies. She, in fact, carried her books with her according to the class subjects she was missing out on so that she could appear for her exams on her return. She would study in the train or off the tennis court. While the rest of her team players went out in the evenings for dance parties, she stayed back in her room to study and sleep early so that she could be ready for practice in the wee hours of the morning. No wonder she was always returning with many trophies that adorn her house even now. Tennis was certainly consuming most of her time but in her heart she was preparing to join the government services as soon as she became eligible. Playing tennis for her was like a training ground for her to prepare for life. It was to groom her to become strong and fearless. It was teaching her personal discipline as also learning to win and lose. The game taught her to play with fairness, taking the stress of hostile crowds at times, controlling the nerves in close matches, apart from giving her the endurance to survive. Tennis also taught her to go beyond herself, while strictly following the rules; she learnt to question injustice, endure hardships and emerge stronger. She also learnt to live within her means. Besides making her travel arrangements all by